

ResearchPDF: A Paper-First PDF Viewer for Chrome

The ResearchPDF tour

<https://research-pdf.croksuter.com>

Abstract

You are reading this document inside ResearchPDF. It is a short paper about the extension itself, so that every feature it describes can be tried right here: the tab you are in, the paper bar above, the annotation tools, and the figure capture. Each section ends with a *Try it* line.

1 One tab for your papers

PDFs opened from the web or from your computer gather in one *PDF tab*, with a tab strip of its own, instead of scattering among your web tabs. Papers go into *projects*: every new PDF starts in the default project, and *Move to project* sends it elsewhere. Projects can be grouped in folders, ordered by dragging, and given an icon, an emoji or a color—which also becomes the icon of their tab in Chrome. Closing a project’s tab and opening it later brings back the same papers.

Try it: press **Alt+Shift+→** to move to the next tab, **Alt+W** to close one and **Alt+Shift+T** to bring it back. The house button opens *Home*: everything you have opened, with reading progress, filters and search.

2 Knowing the paper

When a document is recognised as a paper—by its DOI, its arXiv identifier or its title—a bar under the toolbar shows its venue and year, its citations (with a per-year chart), its references, and BibTeX or APA ready to copy. The data comes from open scholarly databases (Table 1); only identifiers are sent to them.

Table 1: Where the paper bar gets its data.

Source	Provides	Reference
OpenAlex	venues, yearly citations, references	[1]
Crossref	DOIs, publishers, reference counts	[2]
Semantic Scholar	merged preprint and published counts	[3]
arXiv	preprints and their versions	—

Try it: open any paper from arXiv or a publisher; this tour itself is not a published paper, so its bar says so.

3 Notes that travel

Highlights, pen strokes and text notes are kept per document, and a document is recognised by its content rather than its file name. Connect a Google account and they follow you—with the page you were on—to every Chrome profile and device, through a hidden app-only folder in *your own* Drive (Figure 1). The PDF files themselves are never uploaded.

Try it: open the annotation tools (the pen button), highlight a sentence of this paragraph, and reopen this document on another device.

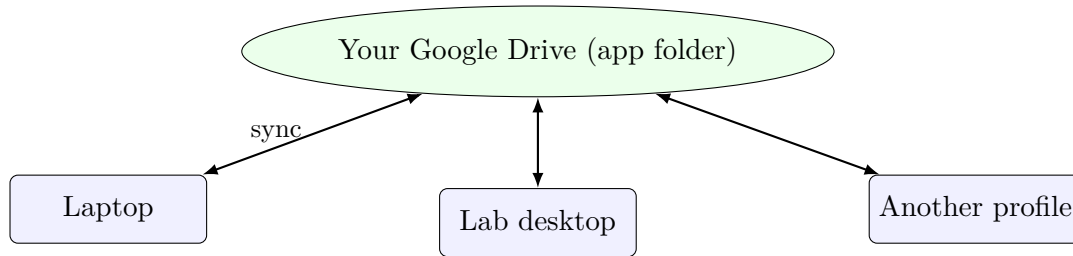


Figure 1: Annotations and reading positions sync through an app-only folder in your own Drive; no server of ours is involved.

4 Figures in one key

Press **S** and drag over any region to copy it as an image, with its source. Press **S** again and the figures and tables of the page are found for you—by a small layout model running on your device [4] together with the PDF’s own captions. Click one to copy it. Figure 2 and Table 1 are good targets.

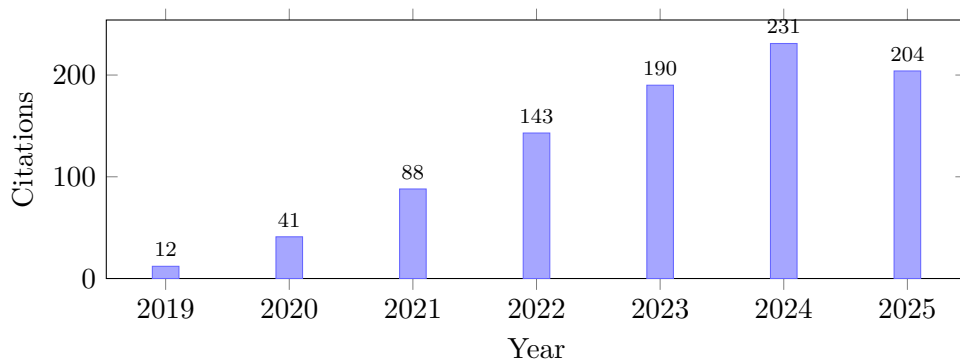


Figure 2: An example of the per-year citation chart the paper bar draws (illustrative numbers).

Try it: press **S** twice now, then click a figure.

References

- [1] J. Priem, H. Piwowar, and R. Orr. OpenAlex: A fully-open index of scholarly works, authors, venues, institutions, and concepts. *arXiv:2205.01833*, 2022.
- [2] G. Hendricks, D. Tkaczyk, J. Lin, and P. Feeney. Crossref: The sustainable source of community-owned scholarly metadata. *Quantitative Science Studies*, 1(1):414–427, 2020.
- [3] R. Kinney et al. The Semantic Scholar Open Data Platform. *arXiv:2301.10140*, 2023.
- [4] T. Sun et al. PP-DocLayout: A unified document layout detection model to accelerate large-scale data construction. *arXiv:2503.17213*, 2025.